battled BRS is bravely trying to fight off the Congress onslaught. KCR's son and party working president K.T. Rama Rao has refuted the charges publicly, but the Enforcement Directorate's arrest of his sister K. Kavitha in the Delhi liquor scam has set off a churn. Several leaders have begun deserting what they perceive as a sinking ship, deepening the pink party's existential crisis. The defectors include three MLAs elected last November. In the cruellest of ironies, in at least 10 of the state's 17 seats, the BRS is fighting 13 candidates who were once with it. In some seats, both the Congress and the BJP contestants are former BRS leaders, mapping the party's implosion on the X- and Y-axes, as it were.

Conscious of the ground slipping under its feet, the BRS is avoiding making any boastful claims. It does not help that the party has no dyed-in-the-wool leaders committed to its ethos to fall back on—unlike old cadre-based organisations. The perils of waging politics as a family concern, and a price analysts say the party is paying for fattening itself on engineered defections even after it won the 2014 assembly election with 63 out of 119 seats and again in 2018, when also it had a comfortable majority. The triangular contest might hand the BRS an advantage in a few constituencies, but a repeat of its 2019 tally of nine seats looks unlikely.

Not willing to give up entirely, KCR is trying to galvanise the party. On April 6, the BRS organised protests in the name of Rythu Deeksha in all assembly constituency headquarters except Hyderabad, to press for immediate relief to distressed farmers. He is also embarking on a statewide tour from April 13.

The BJP is poised to be a *labharthi* of the BRS's present eclipse, and its equally strident criticism of that party is reshaping the electoral battle in most seats as a Congress-BJP shootout. But the saffron party, hoping to improve on its 2019 tally of four, is grappling with a different set of challenges, including the absence of an effective, locally relevant agenda. There is also its state leadership's failure to assimilate outsiders, fractured unity among party veterans, a lack of foresight in utilising the expertise of newer leaders and the limited impact of Hindutva. The party has also failed to build a vibrant organisational structure.

Its advantage lies in having polling booth-level panels in select constituencies. The party is eyeing seats in north Telangana besides those in and around Hyderabad. It is also trying to woo the OBC vote. "The BRS has weakened considerably and the battle is predominantly between the Congress and the BJP," says E. Venkatesu of the political science department at the University of Hyderabad. "The OBC vote will determine the outcome this time." It is something the BRS too is eyeing.

For the moment, the Congress appears to be ahead in the tripartite race. "The party got a fresh lease of life after the assembly poll win while the BRS is yet to reconcile with its defeat," says Harathi Vageeshan who teaches political science at NALSAR University, Hyderabad.

Interestingly, instead of harping on the Centre's report card, the Congress here has extended its assembly poll strategy of 'keeping it local'. A sharper focus on Telangana issues, ranging from loan waivers to irregularities during the BRS rule, is likely to influence the results in several constituencies, say analysts. "In 2019, criticism from the BRS and Congress had unexpectedly benefited the BJP, giving it four seats. This time, the election doesn't seem to revolve around PM Modi. Local and hyperlocal concerns take precedence," says social commentator K. Nageshwar. The BJP says its rivals are diverting attention from the NDA's good work: expect a reversal of focus at Modi and Amit Shah rallies. It hopes that will be the coup de grace for the BRS. Unless the vaastu changes being made at Telangana Bhavan, the BRS headquarters Hyderabad, pull off some voodoo. ■

THEIR WINNING FORMULAS

CONGRESS

- Highlight the implementation of some of the promised Six Guarantees within weeks of assuming office and announce fresh ones
- Capitalise on the BRS's existential crisis, demoralise its cadres and reward defectors with poll tickets
- Target the BJP for failing to keep promises made in 2014 and 2019 such as job creation, doubling farmer incomes, housing for all

BRS

- Reignite the fighting spirit of the separate statehood campaign with KCR at the forefront
- Target the Congress for failing to fulfil its assembly poll-eve promises and reneging on the BRS's people-centric initiatives executed over a decade
- Make poaching of its MLAs an issue as a damage-reduction exercise

BJP

- Present PM Modi as a visionary leader who steered a 'Development Decade' and leverage 'Modi ki Guarantee' and central schemes
- Woo the OBC vote as SCs and STs are largely with the Congress
- Expose the alleged misdeeds of the BRS's decade-long governance